How to Write Fiction: A Practical Guide

A practical guide to the craft, compiled from writers, editors and teachers

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AT A GLANCE

Executive Summary

The key ideas

- Premise is a planning tool that creates cause-and-effect coherence — it tells you what type of conflict your story needs and which events are necessary [1].
- Structure models (three-act, hero's journey, scene/sequel) describe patterns rather than prescribe formulas; writers should choose the model that fits their story [4,5].
- Character arcs prove change through costly choices under pressure, not merely through events happening to the character [2].
- Point of view determines intimacy and knowledge control; third-person limited is the sound default for most stories [3].
- Scenes work when they contain conflict, sensory detail, and end with momentum — each scene should answer one question and open another [6,7].
- Dialogue is scene machinery driven by subtext and voice differentiation; the best conversations leave something unsaid [8,9].
- Revision follows a story ☐ scene ☐ page hierarchy and benefits from a systematic process; practice is deliberate, focusing on one skill at a time [10,11].

CHAPTER 1

Ideas and Premise

Stories begin as sparks — an image, a character, a "what if" question — but a spark becomes a novel only when it hardens into a premise. A premise is more than a logline or marketing copy; it is a developmental tool that generates cause-and-effect coherence throughout the story.

What a premise is

Joe Bunting defines premise as "a single sentence summary of the central plot or argument of a story." Kallista, writing at The Write Practice, extends this: a strong premise does four things. It tells you what type of conflict your story needs, creates a clear cause-and-effect trajectory, helps you decide which events are necessary, and keeps everything consistent. An unfocused premise leads to random conflict where events feel irrelevant and characters act inconsistently because nothing connects to anything else.[1]

John Truby adds that "the great value of the premise is that it allows you to explore the full story and the many forms it might take before you actually write it."[1] In other words, the premise works behind the scenes during drafting, not just as a description afterward.

The five steps to refining premise

Kallista outlines a practical process:[1]

1. **Find your why.** Ask "why" five times to get past surface-level reasons to the emotional core. This makes the story authentic and meaningful.
2. **Discover the point of the story.** Every strong story has a point — an argument about life. If you have several competing points, the story is unfocused. Pick one central point; different points require different types of conflict to prove them.
3. **Condense to fifty words or less.** Distill the story into its simplest idea. If you can't, the story is unfocused.
4. **Clarify protagonist and conflict.** Is the main character the most interesting person? Is the conflict clear — who is fighting whom, over what? Identify the force of antagonism.
5. **Follow the cause-and-effect trajectory.** What is the protagonist's initial strategy? How does their reaction create more problems? What change occurs within the story? The arc of change should prove the story's argument.

Dramatic question and stakes

At the heart of every premise lies a dramatic question: what does the character want, and why does it matter? John Truby calls the character's desire "the engine of the plot" — it must be concrete enough to generate scenes, not just an abstraction like "to belong."[2] The stakes determine whether the reader cares about the answer. For deep personal stakes, find what your character would not, could not, give up.

The dramatic question shapes everything that follows. It determines which conflicts serve the story and which are distractions. When a writer knows the dramatic question, every scene can be evaluated against it: does this scene move us closer to answering it?

Try this: Exercises

1. Write your story's premise in one sentence using the format: "[Character] wants [goal] but [conflict], so they must [action] or [consequence]."
2. Ask "why?" five times about your protagonist's motivation. Does the final answer feel emotionally true?
3. List three scenes from your draft. For each, state the dramatic question it answers and the one it opens.

CHAPTER 2

Structure and Plot

Structure is the skeleton beneath the flesh of a story. Multiple structural models exist, but none is universally superior — the best model is the one that serves your particular story.

Main structural models

Robert McKee formalizes story structure as a discipline in *Story*, describing it not as a template but as principles governing how meaning is generated through conflict, change, and consequence. His quest structure includes: an inciting incident that launches the quest, progressive complications driving toward an unavoidable choice, and a climax that produces the most extreme, irreversible change. Every story, McKee argues, is a series of choices under pressure.[4]

Other models include:[4]

- **Three-Act Structure** (eight beats): Best for any first draft when the writer doesn't yet know the full shape. Divides the story into setup, confrontation, and resolution.
- **Hero's Journey** (twelve beats): Adventure, fantasy, science fiction, myth; follows a protagonist through departure, initiation, and return.
- **Five-Act Structure** (Freytag's Pyramid): Exposition, rising action, climax, falling action, denouement; suits literary fiction and stage drama.
- **Eight-Point Arc** (Nigel Watts): Universal pattern of change applicable to any story in any medium.

Dwight Swain's **scene/sequel model** offers a micro-level structure that operates alongside larger frameworks. Each scene follows goal ☐ conflict ☐ disaster: a character enters with a clear goal, encounters opposition, and ends with a turning point. The sequel that follows moves through reaction ☐ dilemma ☐ decision: the character processes emotionally, weighs constrained options, and makes a choice that launches the next scene. This alternation of action and reaction creates natural rhythm at multiple levels — within scenes, between chapters, and across entire novels.[4]

Try-fail cycles and progressive complications

Try-fail cycles are a common structural element that builds tension. A character attempts to solve a problem, fails, learns something, tries again under worse conditions, and escalates. Each failure raises the stakes and narrows the options until the character faces the ultimate test.[4]

Plotting vs. discovery writing (“pantsing”)

The debate between plotting (outlining before writing) and pantsing (discovery writing, starting with an idea and letting the story unfold) is often overstated. Method does not determine quality — consistency, craft, and revision do.[5]

Stephen King describes his process as “uncovering a fossil” — the story already exists; the writer digs it up. Margaret Atwood lets characters lead her through drafts. J.K. Rowling, by contrast, is a legendary plotter; John Grisham and Brandon Sanderson outline extensively. George R.R. Martin calls himself a “gardener” but keeps detailed notes.[5]

Most working authors are “planters” — hybrids who know their beginning and ending but discover the middle. Genre tendencies guide but do not constrain: plotting tends to work better for thrillers, mysteries, epic fantasy, and sci-fi (where clue placement, world-building, and multi--POV continuity matter); discovery writing tends to suit literary fiction, memoir, and short fiction (where character interiority and thematic resonance take priority). But these are tendencies, not rules.[5]

Try this: Exercises

1. Map your current draft onto one structural model (three-act, scene/sequel, or McKee’s quest). Does the fit feel natural or forced?
2. Identify three try-fail cycles in your story. Does each attempt raise the stakes or narrow the options?
3. If you normally plot, try writing one chapter without notes. If you normally pants, try outlining the next three chapters before writing them. Note what changes in the result.

CHAPTER 3

Character

Characters are the agents through which plot happens and theme is expressed. Good characters are not merely people who exist in a story; they are people whose desires, flaws, and choices drive the narrative forward.

Want, need, and the lie

John Truby's framework distinguishes three elements that together create a complete character:[2]

- **Want** (desire): What the character is chasing. It must be concrete enough to generate scenes — not simply "to belong" but "to be accepted by this specific community."
- **Need**: What would actually make the character whole. Truby splits this into psychological need (a flaw hurting only the character) and moral need (a flaw through which the character hurts others).
- **Lie**: A false conclusion about how the world works, usually formed in a specific past moment. Lisa Cron calls it the "misbelief"; K.M. Weiland calls it "the Lie the Character Believes." Crucially, the lie must have been useful at some point — if it never worked, abandoning it costs nothing.

Arcs proven by choice

An arc is what a character becomes willing to do — not what they are (that is backstory) and not their mood (that is transient). It is a sequence of choices under pressure that changes what actions are available to them. Change is proven by a choice that costs exactly what the lie was protecting. If the lie protected the character from being seen, stage a scene where they must be seen. The proof must be a choice, not a feeling.[2]

Charles Dickens' *Great Expectations* chapter 56 illustrates this perfectly: Pip holds a convict's hand in public, doing what the earlier Pip could not bear. He does not merely feel differently; he acts differently when it matters.

Secondary characters need a position on the protagonist's lie rather than their own full arc. They serve as living answers to the same moral question. When everyone transforms, nobody does.[2]

Making characters distinct

Distinct characters have active flaws, not passive ones. A character who is “shy” is less interesting than one who is shy specifically because she believes speaking up will expose her as inadequate. Specific desires create specific actions. Motivation drives plot forward because desire compels the character to act even when obstacles block the way.

Try this: Exercises

1. Name three moments where your protagonist does something they could not have done earlier in the book. If you cannot find them with page numbers, you have a description of an arc, not an arc (ChapterMuse’s test).[2]
2. Write your protagonist’s lie in one sentence. Now ask: what would it cost them to stop believing it?
3. List your secondary characters and assign each one a position on the protagonist’s lie (believer, challenger, victim, exemplar).

CHAPTER 4

Point of View and Voice

Point of view determines how close the reader feels to a character's thoughts and experiences, and whose knowledge controls what the reader knows and when. Getting POV right is foundational — errors here ripple through every scene.

Three main choices

Editor World identifies three primary POV choices, plus second person as a special case:[3]

- **First person** ("I"): Inside one character's head. Creates intimacy and strong voice — the narrator's personality colors every sentence. Natural home for unreliable narrators. Cost: confinement. The reader knows only what the narrator knows and witnesses only what the narrator witnesses. Scenes elsewhere cannot be shown directly.
- **Third person limited** ("he"/"she"/"they", close to one character): The most widely used POV in modern fiction. Combines first-person closeness with more flexibility. Distance is adjustable — can press in tightly (close third) or pull back slightly. Can follow multiple characters via chapter-by-chapter rotation while keeping one mind per scene at a time. Editor World calls it "the default worth reaching for when no stronger reason points elsewhere."
- **Third person omniscient**: Narrator not tied to any character. Can enter any character's thoughts, report events in multiple places, step back to comment on the world. Suits large casts, long timespans, stories where society or family shape matters more than one person's experience. The danger is distance and "head-hopping" — the weak version where perspective slides between characters within a scene without reason. True omniscience reads as a single controlling intelligence.
- **Second person** ("you"): Rarest. Best reserved for specific effects at shorter lengths. Can feel like a trick over sustained use.

Narrative distance and filtering

Narrative distance refers to how close the reader feels to a character's thoughts and experiences.[3] Close narration immerses the reader in the character's immediate perception; distant narration provides more context, commentary, and temporal range. The key is consistency — drifting between tight close and detached narration without intent confuses rather than enriches.

Filtering phrases like "she saw," "he noticed," "she heard" add layers between reader and experience. Remove filters for closer POV: "she heard the door slam" becomes "the door slammed."

Filtering is not always wrong, but it is a choice — and too much of it distances the reader from the scene.[3]

Tense

Past tense is the conventional default for fiction; it gives the narrator the advantage of having lived through the events and looking back. Present tense creates immediacy and urgency, placing the reader alongside the character in real time. The choice affects pacing and tone as much as grammar.

Try this: Exercises

1. Read a scene aloud. Count how many sentences contain filtering words (saw, felt, noticed, heard, wondered). If more than one in five contains a filter, consider tightening.
2. Test your POV consistency: in a multi-character scene, can you identify at any moment whose perspective you are in? If not, is that intentional (omniscient) or accidental (head-hopping)?
3. Rewrite a paragraph in both close third and omniscient. Notice how the information available to the reader changes.

CHAPTER 5

Scene Craft and Pacing

Scenes are the building blocks of storytelling. They advance plot by creating tension, resolving conflicts, and introducing new information. They also serve as character development tools and establish emotional connections between readers and characters.

Four essential elements

Behind The Draft identifies four components that every well-constructed scene must have:[6]

1. **Setting** — physical location or emotional/psychological atmosphere rendered through sensory details.
2. **Character actions** — specific and concrete ("She rummaged through her purse for her phone" rather than "She looked for her phone"). Actions reveal motivations, desires, and flaws.
3. **Dialogue** — reveals character traits, relationships, and backstory; exchanges information but does more than that.
4. **Conflict** — internal (self-doubt, moral struggle) or external (arguing with a friend, facing a physical threat). Conflict creates tension and raises stakes.

Effective scenes balance both inner turmoil and outer challenges, showing how internal struggle influences external actions and vice versa.[6]

Conflict versus obstacle

Wendy Ogilvie draws a crucial distinction: an obstacle slows a character down, but conflict forces them to make a difficult choice.[7] A locked door is an obstacle; a locked door that prevents the character from escaping a fire is conflict. Conflict demands that the character risk something — status, safety, love, identity.

Ogilvie's thirty-question checklist emphasizes that curiosity, secrets, uncertainty, emotional vulnerability, difficult choices, and time pressure can all keep readers engaged — tension does not always mean loud, dramatic shouting matches. Each page should contain something that encourages the reader to keep going.[7]

Sensory detail and description

Sensory details should resonate with the scene's emotional core. Include at least one sensory detail per scene that reinforces the mood, but choose one or two relevant details rather than overwhelming the reader. Integrate description into action and dialogue rather than pausing the scene for info dumps. Selective description highlights key elements that reveal character or advance plot.[6]

Pacing tools

Pacing is controlled through sentence length, paragraph breaks, and the balance between action and reflection. Short sentences create urgency; longer ones add depth. Cliffhangers work by raising more questions than answers, often positioning the reader at the moment before a major event or revelation.[6] Ogilvie advises that pace should match the emotional intensity of the scene, and that long passages should be broken up with dialogue, action, and interior thoughts.[7]

Ending scenes effectively

A scene should end with momentum — answer the scene question while introducing a new one. Something should change before the scene finishes. Common mistakes include ending scenes after everything has been resolved (too neat), trying to make every scene action-packed (unnecessary), and explaining emotions instead of creating them.[7]

Try this: Exercises

1. Audit your last ten scenes. For each, identify: the goal, the conflict (not just obstacle), the sensory detail, and the change at the end.
2. Pick a scene where the character faces a physical obstacle. Add an internal dimension — what does this obstacle reveal about their inner struggle?
3. Read a scene aloud and mark where your reading speed changes. Do short sentences cluster during action? Do longer sentences appear during reflection? Adjust if the rhythm contradicts the content.

CHAPTER 6

Dialogue

Dialogue is not decoration — it is scene machinery. A useful dialogue pass tracks variables separately: objective, voice differentiation, subtext, exposition load, pacing, clarity, tags and beats, emotional progression, and POV pressure.[8]

Subtext: the iceberg model

Shyam Babu describes subtext as the hidden meaning beneath surface words. In real life, people do not always say what they think or feel — they indicate, avoid, or hide it. Fiction dialogue should do the same. Only a small part of meaning sits above water; most emotions, history, and tension remain below.[9]

Babu offers a five-step process:[9]

1. Know what the character really feels before writing the dialogue.
2. Don't let them say it outright — instead of "I'm jealous," have the character change the topic or ask indirect questions.
3. Use conflict or tension — subtext is most effective when characters avoid saying what they truly mean.
4. Combine actions with dialogue — body language supports subtext.
5. Trust the reader — don't explain everything. Not every line needs subtext; clarity matters in serious situations.

Romance relies on emotional tension in subtext; thrillers rely on secrecy and misdirection; horror uses unease and uncertainty.[9]

Voice differentiation

Critique Space identifies voice differentiation as one of the fastest ways dialogue sounds unnatural: letting every character speak with the same rhythm, vocabulary, and self-awareness. Look for differences in sentence length, formality and slang, directness versus avoidance, emotional restraint versus overflow, use of metaphor, jokes, and repetition, and willingness to answer the actual question. A practical test: remove names and tags from an exchange; if you cannot tell who is speaking, voices are too blended.[8]

Attribution: tags and beats

Tags should support the line, not compete with it. Martin Cavannagh at Reedsy notes that fear of reusing “said” and “asked” leads inexperienced writers to incorrect tags like “he yawned” or “she growled.” These mark the writer as amateur. Clean tags are invisible; action beats (“He stretched and yawned, putting down the coffee cup”) reveal character without calling attention to themselves.[12] Critique Space warns against overwritten tags explaining what the line already conveys and against action beats attached to every line, creating drag.[8]

Exposition load

Natural dialogue rarely delivers exposition cleanly. Warning signs include overuse of names in conversation, long explanatory replies to simple questions, characters recapping shared history in full sentences, and information delivered at exactly the moment the reader needs it with no resistance. Move some exposition into action, interiority, or narration. Keep only parts that create conflict, misunderstanding, or emotional charge.[8]

Emotional progression

A conversation should not be emotionally flat unless flatness is the point. Track starting temperature, escalation and de-escalation points, unexpected reversals, and final emotional residue. Variation gives dramatic scenes more impact.[8]

Try this: Exercises

1. Read a dialogue-heavy scene and remove all tags and beats. Can you still tell who is speaking? If not, strengthen voice differentiation.
2. Mark every instance where a character says exactly what they feel. Replace at least two with subtext — an indirect statement, a deflection, a pause.
3. Check attribution tags. Are any non-speech verbs used as tags (“he whispered,” “she thundered”) where “said” or a beat would suffice?

CHAPTER 7

Description and Setting

Description and setting do more than paint pictures — they create the world in which characters act and influence how the reader perceives those actions.

Show, don't tell — clarified

Blake Reichenbach clarifies that "show, don't tell" is not simply "avoid emotion words." It is the difference between summary and scene, between abstraction and concrete particularity. The deeper principle: fiction should create experience rather than report it. The reader should be placed inside a rendered moment and allowed to feel it themselves. Telling is often what "reaching for effect" looks like — when prose announces itself as writing. Elmore Leonard's advice applies: "If it sounds like writing, I rewrite it."[13]

Scene versus summary

Both showing (scene) and telling (summary) are necessary tools. Summary is not a failure of craft — it is a pacing tool. The error is using summary where scene is needed, most often at moments of high emotional or thematic significance. Transitional passages — moving characters through time and geography — are well-suited to summary.[13]

Reichenbach's example illustrates the distinction clearly:[13]

- Telling: "Marcus was furious when he saw the letter. He felt betrayed by someone he had trusted completely."
- Showing: "Marcus read the letter twice, then set it on the table with the careful flatness of someone handling something that might break. He went to the window. Outside, two children were chasing a dog across the neighbor's lawn, laughing. He watched them for a long time without seeing them."

When telling is right

Telling works well for narrative summary, moments of directness and compression ("He was not a good man, though he had always thought of himself as one"), and strong first-person narrators whose voice works by telling (Nick Carraway in *Gatsby*; Humbert Humbert in *Lolita*). The rule is to be deliberate: tell because you've chosen to, not because you haven't figured out how to render the scene.[13]

Sensory specificity

Concrete, specific, sensory language tends toward showing. Selective precision matters more than photographic completeness. Engage senses beyond sight — sound, smell, temperature, physical sensation — because these create immediacy that visual description alone cannot.[13]

Avoiding laundry-list descriptions

Martin Cavannagh at Reedsy identifies "laundry list" descriptions — head-to-toe character introductions listing hair, eyes, glasses, clothing all at once — as a common first-author mistake. Repetitive mention of the same details ("liquid brown eyes") also signals inexperience. Fix: describe through behaviors, actions, body language, and dialogue instead. Ian Rankin's approach — physical description that implies more than it states — is a model.[12]

Worldbuilding without info-dumping

Worldbuilding details should be integrated into action and dialogue rather than paused for. Describe the world as characters experience it, not as an encyclopedia entry. The reader learns about the magic system, the political order, or the technology when it matters to the character's current goal.

Try this: Exercises

1. Find a passage of pure description (three or more sentences of setting). Convert one sentence from telling to showing by adding a sensory or action-based detail.
2. Locate your longest character introduction. Does it read like a catalog? Break it up by weaving description into the character's actions.
3. Read a scene aloud. Listen for explanatory parentheses and emotional labeling. Are they serving the scene or interrupting it?

CHAPTER 8

Revision

Revision is where good writing becomes great. Most first drafts lose at least 10% of content during editing — words, sentences, even whole chapters may be cut, rearranged, or reimagined. Revision is not about fixing typos; it is about making the story work.[10]

The ten-step process

Savannah Gilbo outlines a systematic approach:[10]

1. **Shift mindset from author to editor.** Editing is analytical, not creative. Resist emotional attachment to words. Create a physical ritual to signal the transition.
2. **Read the entire draft without making edits.** Experience the manuscript as a whole — reveals the forest instead of individual trees. Many major problems are not obvious when focused on sentences but become glaring in complete narrative flow. Make note of gut reactions (confusion, boredom, excitement).
3. **Create a reverse outline.** A scene-by-scene outline of what you actually wrote, not what you intended. Reveals true structure rather than imagined structure. Focus on what each chapter accomplishes, not just what it contains.
4. **Create a strategic revision plan.** Editing without a plan is like renovating randomly. Three levels: story-level first, scene-level next, page-level last. Attempting to edit without this hierarchy is the single biggest mistake writers make — perfecting sentences in chapters that ultimately need rewriting or cutting.
5. **Execute big-picture story-level edits.** Adjust foundation before decorating rooms. Does plot create genuine momentum? Do characters have clear, consistent motivations? What is the story really about beneath the surface?
6. **Get fresh eyes on the manuscript.** After the second draft, outside feedback identifies issues the creator cannot see. Developmental editors provide expert, big-picture feedback; beta readers offer reader perspective.
7. **Incorporate feedback strategically.** Don't take all feedback literally; filter through your vision for the story.
8. **Polish scenes for maximum impact.** Every scene should earn its place by serving multiple purposes simultaneously — advancing plot, revealing character, reinforcing theme.
9. **Perfect prose in the fourth draft.** Granular line-by-line craft elements: precise word choice, elegant sentence structures, rhythmic paragraph flow. Read work aloud — ears catch issues eyes miss.

10. **Choose publishing path and final polishing.** Traditional publishing handles additional editing; self-publishing requires investment in line editing, copy editing, and proofreading.

Hierarchy of fixes

The critical insight is hierarchy: fix story-level problems before scene-level problems, and scene-level before page-level. Perfection in a chapter that will be cut is wasted effort. Similarly, the most common direction of loss during revision is downward — 10% or more of a first draft disappears because exposition is trimmed, redundant scenes are removed, or descriptive passages are compressed.[10]

Getting feedback

Fresh eyes catch what the creator cannot see. Beta readers read as audiences do and flag confusion, boredom, and emotional disconnection. Developmental editors bring craft expertise and can identify structural issues that readers sense but cannot articulate. The key is to filter feedback through your vision — not every suggestion is equally valuable, and not every reader is reading for the same thing.[10]

Try this: Exercises

1. Print your draft or export it to a different format. Read it straight through without editing. Mark pages with “P” (plot issue), “C” (character issue), “S” (slow section), and “!” (excitement).
2. Build a reverse outline: one line per scene describing what it accomplishes. Scan for scenes that do nothing, scenes that repeat each other, and gaps where something should happen.
3. Read a chapter aloud. Record where your tongue trips, where your ear detects repetition, and where your pace naturally quickens or slows. These are indicators of prose rhythm and pacing.

CHAPTER 9

Practice and Process

Writing fiction is a craft that improves through deliberate practice, not merely through accumulated time at the keyboard. As Borges observed (and Joslyn Chase echoes), writing is "fire plus algebra" — art and technique can coexist, and technique can be learned and refined.[11]

Deliberate practice

Joslyn Chase recommends choosing one area of writing, studying what skilled writers do in that area, and putting it into practice specifically. The best practice is deliberate — focused on a single craft element rather than general writing time. She identifies five core skills that every fiction writer should develop:[11]

1. **Structure**: Understanding how stories are built — inciting incidents, turning points, climax, resolution. Study successful stories in your genre to see how they arrange their events.
2. **Point of view**: Mastering the relationship between narrator and reader. Knowing when to be inside a character's head and when to observe from outside.
3. **Dialogue**: Making conversations natural while serving plot and character. Differentiating voices.
4. **Emotion**: Creating genuine emotional responses in readers without over-explaining. Using specific details to trigger feeling.
5. **Hooks**: Opening scenes and chapters effectively; keeping readers turning pages. Understanding what creates curiosity and tension.

Reading as a writer

Inessa Sage describes reading as a writer as fundamentally different from reading for pleasure. It means going beyond the surface to analyze how and why a story works — studying authorial choices, recognizing patterns, and applying insights to one's own writing.[14]

Sage recommends paying attention to four dimensions:[14]

- **Structure**: Map the backbone of the narrative. Identify inciting incident, major turning points, pacing changes. Compare multiple books in a genre to see structural patterns.
- **Characters**: Ask what motivates them, what their goals are, how their arcs evolve. Pay attention to dialogue and internal monologues for hidden character information.
- **Style**: Notice sentence structure, word choices, imagery, symbolism. Each writer has a distinct voice.

- **Tension and pacing**: Note where tension increases, how authors slow down for impact or speed up, how transitions between plot points work.

Practical method: keep a journal documenting what worked and did not work, notable phrases and sentences, favorite quotes and why they worked, recurring themes. Over time this becomes a resource for writing projects.[14]

Common beginner mistakes

Reedsy editors summarize six frequent errors in first-time authors: wordiness (over-description and redundant language), telling rather than showing, laundry-list descriptions, head-hopping (POV bouncing between characters), inappropriate dialogue tags, and misplaced modifiers.[12] Reading the manuscript aloud is consistently recommended as a diagnostic tool — ears catch issues that eyes miss.

Consistency over perfection

No writing habit is universally superior. The best routine is the one that reliably gets a writer from blank page to completed manuscript. For pantsers, daily word count goals and a running story bible help. For plotters, leaving room for surprise and testing outlines with the "so what?" question prevent paralysis. Both produce real books.[5]

Try this: Exercises

1. Choose one of Chase's five core skills. For one week, read with that skill in mind — annotate how successful writers handle it, and write two short scenes that deliberately practice it.
2. Start a reading journal. After each book, record one structural observation, one character insight, and one stylistic note.
3. Set a consistent writing schedule (time of day, duration, word-count target) for thirty days. Track what you produce. Evaluate the output, not the method.

PERSPECTIVES

Where the Advice Disagrees

Not all craft advice converges. Some of the most productive tensions in fiction writing arise from genuinely competing schools. Here are the major disagreements and when each side applies.

Plotting vs. discovery writing

Plotters argue that structure prevents wandering drafts and heavy revision. Pantsers argue that organic discovery produces more authentic character voice and genuine surprise. The Chapter Blog notes that the labels are less binary than commonly portrayed — most working authors are plantsers, knowing beginning and ending but discovering the middle.[5] One More Draft adds that structure models describe patterns rather than prescribe formulas.[4]

Resolution: Method does not determine quality [5]. Plotting tends to suit genres where clue placement, world-building, and continuity matter (thrillers, fantasy, sci-fi). Discovery writing tends to suit character-driven work where interiority and thematic resonance are paramount (literary fiction, memoir) [4,5]. Either approach produces real books if the writer revises thoroughly.

Show vs. tell

The popular formulation “show, don’t tell” is often misunderstood as “never name emotions.” Reichenbach clarifies that the real distinction is between summary and scene, not between emotion words and their absence.[13] Summary is a valid pacing tool; the error is using it where scene is needed. Strong first-person narrators (Nick Carraway, Humbert Humbert) tell effectively because their voice carries the telling.

Resolution: Show (scene) at moments of high emotional or thematic significance. Tell (summary) for transitions, compression, and when the narrator’s voice benefits from direct statement [13]. Be deliberate about which mode you are using.

“Never use adverbs”

The prohibition against adverbs originated as a corrective to weak usage — adverbs bolsters nouns and verbs unnecessarily. But strong adverbs serve a purpose: they specify manner, degree, or timing in ways that a verb alone cannot. The issue is not adverbs per se but weak adverbs replacing precise verbs.

Resolution: Prefer strong verbs over adverb-bolstered weak verbs [12]. Keep adverbs that add genuine specification. Read aloud to hear redundancy.

One POV per scene vs. head-hopping

Strict adherence to one POV per scene prevents confusion but can feel restrictive in omniscient narratives. Head-hopping — shifting perspective between characters within a scene — is a mistake when unintentional but effective when the omniscient narrator intentionally broadens the perspective to reveal dramatic irony or contrast.

Resolution: First-person and third-limited benefit from strict single-POV-per-scene discipline [3]. Third-omniscient can head-hop intentionally when the shift serves a clear purpose (revealing what one character does not know, contrasting two characters' reactions to the same event) [3].

Structure as template vs. pattern

Some writers treat structural models as templates to fill in (hero's journey beats in order). Others treat them as patterns discovered after the fact — descriptions of what successful stories share, not prescriptions of what every story must do. One More Draft and the Chapter Blog both emphasize the pattern-view.[4,5]

Resolution: Use structure as a diagnostic and organizational tool, not a formula. If a model illuminates your story's shape, apply it. If forcing a beat into your story distorts it, bend the model.

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